

The history of localisation

The origins of localisation can be traced to translation, where a speech or written document is translated from one language to another. Once computing devices became common, there was need to organise and customise the translation for software environments. That's how localisation was born. You can understand the growth of localisation with the example of the Debian distribution. Figure 2 shows the Debian versions and their language support, with a steady increase in the number of languages.

Debian Version	Code name	Release date	#of languages
3	woody	2002-07-19	40
4	etch	2007-04-08	58
5	lenny	2009-02-14	63
6	squeeze	2011-02-06	70

Figure 2: Debian releases and language support

While early localisers had to struggle with simple editors, specialised tools and platforms were later developed to support localisation.

Localisation vs internationalisation

Internationalisation is usually abbreviated to i18n (as there are 18 letters between the letters 'I' and 'n'). It denotes the packaging of the strings used in software so that the corresponding strings from a user's language can be deployed without impacting the functionality of the application. Apart from that, internationalisation is a set of practices followed by developers so that the application presents information and/or processes as per the expectations of the target users. Localisation, for most common usage, is concerned with translating the menu strings and application messages to the users' desired language. This requires a good knowledge of the target language, and a style guide for translation. For documentation localisation, a good command of the language and translation skills will also be needed.

As can be seen from the chart (Figure 3), localisation and internationalisation are closely interlinked, so work on both never ends. As long as software or the software environment changes, localisation work continues. This also explains why, while there are so many languages spoken in the world, localisation is limited to a smaller subset of them.

Localisation initiatives in Indian languages

IndLinux: The earliest localisation initiatives in India were from IndLinux, a Free Software group. IndLinux was started by Prakash Advani and Venkatesh Hariharan in December 1999 as a portal. Linux Bangalore/2001 was the first event when Indian Free Software groups got together to share developments on localisation. At Linux/Bangalore 2002, GNOME in Hindi was demonstrated. Various teams working with other Indian languages contributed to other language versions of GNOME, which resulted in the release

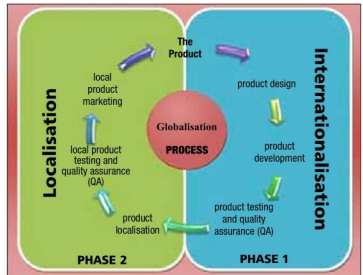


Figure 3: Internationalisation and localisation (<http://commons.wikimedia.org/wiki/File:Globalisationchart>)

of Rangoli 1.0 beta in 2005, supporting several languages. Other teams brought out language-specific Linux distributions around the same time. The language support became part of mainstream distributions like Fedora, Debian and Ubuntu over the years. When Ubuntu 11.04 was released on April 28, 2011, it included boot-time local support for the following Indian languages apart from English: Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Nepali, Tamil and Telugu.

FUEL: Frequently Used Entries for Localisation (FUEL) was initiated by Rajesh Ranjan to improve the quality of localisation, by standardising the translations for most common words or phrases. Twelve languages have been part of the initiative.

Microsoft's initiative: Windows 7 has been released with support for 95 languages. For Indian languages, Microsoft has a language portal called BhashaIndia, through which it enables users of its products to participate in localisation.

What's next?

Through this series of articles, I aim to provide information on various localisation platforms and tools, which can help readers to become active contributors in improving the language support for their preferred languages. I would appreciate your feedback at arjunaraoc@ieee.org.

For more information, visit:

<http://indlinux.org/>

<https://fedorahosted.org/fuel/>

<http://bhashaindia.com/> 

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